

# Top 30 Fishing Spots Around Columbus, Ohio

Thirty places to wet a line within an easy drive of Columbus. Bring a valid **Ohio fishing license**, then use each spot's **fish**, **bait**, **website** (when there is one), and local tip.

## Before you go

- ☐ Current Ohio fishing license — [ODNR licenses](#)
- ☐ Check size/bag limits for what you're keeping — [ODNR fishing regulations](#)
- ☐ Rod + reel, spare hooks/soft plastics, pliers, net for bigger water
- ☐ Sunscreen, water, bug spray (summer), warm layers (shoulder seasons)
- ☐ Trash bag — pack out what you pack in

**License note:** This guide is not a substitute for ODNR regulations. Access and rules change — confirm posted park/reservoir rules the morning of your trip.

**How to use:** Circle 2–3 nearby spots, pick a half-day window, and leave if pressure or weather turns.

## Bait cheat sheet (central Ohio favorites)

| Target                            | Often works                                                                                             |
|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Bluegill / sunfish                | Worms, waxworms, tiny jigs, small spinners                                                              |
| Crappie                           | Minnows, 1/16-oz jigs + soft plastics, small tubes                                                      |
| Largemouth / smallmouth bass      | Soft plastics (worms/creature baits), spinnerbaits, crankbaits, topwater (warm months)                  |
| Saugeye / walleye                 | Jigs + minnows or soft plastics, crankbaits along drop-offs                                             |
| Channel / blue / flathead catfish | Cut bait, chicken liver, nightcrawlers, stink baits (channel); live/cut bait deeper for blues/flatheads |
| White bass                        | Small spinners, spoons, shad-imitating soft plastics                                                    |
| Carp                              | Corn, dough balls, worms (where legal / ethical for the water)                                          |

## Reservoirs & big water

### 1. Hoover Reservoir — Westerville / NE Columbus

**Fish:** Crappie (black & white), channel / blue / flathead catfish, largemouth & smallmouth bass, saugeye, bluegill, white bass.

**Bait:** Crappie — minnows or 1/16-oz jigs + soft plastics near cover; catfish — cut bait / liver on the north end; bass — plastics & crankbaits; saugeye — jigs/crankbaits on drop-offs.

**Web:** [ODNR — Hoover Reservoir Fishing Area](#)

**Local tip:** Pick one arm and fish it well. 10 HP outboard limit. Westerville food/coffee ~10 minutes from most ramps.

**Nearby:** Blendon Woods / Inniswood if you want a short walk.

### 2. Alum Creek Lake — Lewis Center / Delaware County

**Fish:** Largemouth & smallmouth bass, saugeye, crappie, channel catfish, bluegill.

**Bait:** Bass — soft plastics in weeds (3–10 ft) or topwater; smallmouth — plastics/crankbaits on points & rock; crappie — minnows/jigs; catfish — cut bait / crawlers.

**Web:** [ODNR — Alum Creek Lake Fishing Area](#) · [Alum Creek State Park](#)

**Local tip:** Weekday mornings beat weekend boat traffic. Confirm ramp/lot status seasonally.

**Nearby:** Lewis Center / Polaris for food after you load up.

### 3. Griggs Reservoir — NW Columbus

**Fish:** Largemouth bass, bluegill, crappie, channel catfish; occasional hybrid striped bass / white bass reports.

**Bait:** Worms & small jigs for panfish; soft plastics / spinnerbaits for bass; cut bait or crawlers for cats along deeper edges.

**Web:** [City of Columbus — Griggs Reservoir Park](#)

**Local tip:** Shared path with bikes/kayaks — keep casts and gear tidy.

**Nearby:** UA / Hilliard lunch along Fishinger / Trabue corridors.

### 4. O'Shaughnessy Reservoir — Dublin / NW

**Fish:** Largemouth bass, bluegill, crappie, channel catfish.

**Bait:** Soft plastics & spinnerbaits for bass; worms/jigs for bluegill & crappie; cut bait for cats.

**Web:** [City of Columbus — O'Shaughnessy Reservoir Park](#)

**Local tip:** Wind pushes hard — fish protected pockets when gusty.

**Nearby:** Historic Dublin / Bridge Park for coffee and a walk.

### 5. Buckeye Lake — SE of Columbus

**Fish:** Largemouth bass, crappie, bluegill, channel catfish, saugeye (varies by year).

**Bait:** Plastics & spinnerbaits for bass; minnows/jigs for crappie; crawlers/cut bait for cats.

**Web:** [Buckeye Lake State Park](#)

**Local tip:** Summer weekends are crowded — dawn or weekday. Confirm public access vs private docks.

**Nearby:** Lake-town food; don't assume every dock is public.

### 6. Delaware Lake — Delaware State Park

**Fish:** Largemouth bass, crappie, bluegill, channel catfish, saugeye.

**Bait:** Soft plastics for bass; minnows/jigs for crappie; crawlers/cut bait for cats; jigs along deeper structure for saugeye.

**Web:** [Delaware State Park](#)

**Local tip:** Pair fishing with a park picnic; check launch fees/hours.

**Nearby:** Downtown Delaware for a sit-down meal.

### 7. Deer Creek Lake — Deer Creek State Park

**Fish:** Largemouth bass, crappie, bluegill, channel catfish, saugeye / hybrid striped bass (check current ODNR notes).

**Bait:** Plastics & crankbaits for bass; minnows/jigs for crappie; cut bait for cats; spoons/jigs for open-water hybrids when active.

**Web:** [Deer Creek State Park](#)

**Local tip:** Plan a half- or full-day trip — farther than metro ponds. Gas up in Columbus.

**Nearby:** Pack snacks; park amenities are the main food option.

### 8. Madison Lake — Madison Lake State Park

**Fish:** Largemouth bass, bluegill, crappie, channel catfish.

**Bait:** Worms & tiny jigs (great for kids/bluegill); soft plastics for bass; cut bait/crawlers for cats.

**Web:** [Madison Lake State Park](#)

**Local tip:** Easier to “read” than huge reservoirs — ideal teach-a-friend water.

**Nearby:** Pack a cooler; amenities are park-basic.

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## Metro Parks lakes & ponds

### 9. Sharon Woods Metro Park

**Fish:** Largemouth bass, bluegill, crappie, channel catfish (lake).

**Bait:** Worms / small jigs for panfish; soft plastics for bass; crawlers for cats.

**Web:** [Sharon Woods](#)

**Local tip:** Share shore with walkers; early morning is calmer.

**Nearby:** Park restrooms + Westerville food.

### 10. Antrim Park — Worthington

**Fish:** Largemouth bass, bluegill, crappie, channel catfish.

**Bait:** Worms & bobbers for bluegill; small plastics for bass; liver/crawlers for cats.

**Web:** [Antrim Park \(City of Columbus\)](#)

**Local tip:** After-work friendly — travel light; geese are part of the deal.

**Nearby:** Worthington / High Street food.

### 11. Rocky Fork Metro Park

**Fish:** Largemouth bass, bluegill, crappie (where fishing is posted).

**Bait:** Worms, small jigs, soft plastics.

**Web:** [Rocky Fork](#)

**Local tip:** Confirm fishing-allowed shoreline vs wildlife-only zones.

**Nearby:** Gahanna / New Albany food corridors.

### 12. Pickerington Ponds Metro Park

**Fish:** Panfish and bass in ponds where fishing is allowed (confirm posts — some wetland areas are wildlife-first).

**Bait:** Worms, tiny jigs, small soft plastics.

**Web:** [Pickerington Ponds](#)

**Local tip:** Soft banks after rain; bring binoculars either way.

**Nearby:** Pickerington snacks/groceries.

### 13. Glacier Ridge Metro Park

**Fish:** Bluegill, bass, and pond panfish where posted.

**Bait:** Worms, small jigs, soft plastics.

**Web:** [Glacier Ridge](#)

**Local tip:** Little shade — summer heat is real.

**Nearby:** Dublin / Plain City food depending on entrance.

### 14. Prairie Oaks Metro Park — Big Darby corridor

**Fish:** Smallmouth / rock bass / sunfish in creek sections where fishing is allowed (Darby is a sensitive system — obey all posts).

**Bait:** Light tackle — small inline spinners, soft plastics, worms (no heavy gear).

**Web:** [Prairie Oaks](#)

**Local tip:** After storms, wait for clearer, safer water.

**Nearby:** West-side / Hilliard food; prairie walk if the bite dies.

## 15. Battelle Darby Creek Metro Park

**Fish:** Creek sunfish, bass species where posted; some areas are catch-and-release or closed — read signs.

**Bait:** Light spinning gear — worms, tiny spinners, small plastics.

**Web:** [Battelle Darby Creek](#)

**Local tip:** Stay out of restricted/sensitive zones.

**Nearby:** Nature center for orientation; pack lunch.

## 16. Three Creeks Metro Park

**Fish:** Creek sunfish, bass, occasional catfish in deeper holes.

**Bait:** Worms, small jigs, soft plastics, light spinners.

**Web:** [Three Creeks](#)

**Local tip:** After heavy rain, current spikes — safety first.

**Nearby:** South/east Columbus food; easy 90-minute stop.

## 17. Blacklick Woods Metro Park

**Fish:** Pond/creek panfish and bass where fishing is posted.

**Bait:** Worms, tiny jigs, soft plastics.

**Web:** [Blacklick Woods](#)

**Local tip:** Roots and mud — grip shoes beat flip-flops.

**Nearby:** East-side food on Brice / Main corridors.

## 18. Scioto Audubon Metro Park

**Fish:** Urban river/pond access for bass, panfish, and catfish where posted.

**Bait:** Soft plastics for bass; worms for panfish; cut bait for cats.

**Web:** [Scioto Audubon](#)

**Local tip:** Perfect “one hour after work” stop — park once, travel light.

**Nearby:** Brewery District / German Village after you rinse off.

## 19. Homestead Park — Hilliard

**Fish:** Bluegill, bass, channel catfish (pond).

**Bait:** Worms under a bobber (kid-friendly); small plastics for bass; liver/crawlers for cats.

**Web:** [Homestead Park \(Hilliard\)](#)

**Local tip:** First-bluegill day water — quit while it's still fun.

**Nearby:** Old Hilliard / Hilliard Rome food.

## 20. Darby Creek park access (metro west)

**Fish:** Sunfish, smallmouth/rock bass where public fishing is posted.

**Bait:** Ultra-light — worms, tiny spinners, small plastics.

**Web:** Start at [Prairie Oaks](#) / [Battelle Darby Creek](#) for legal access points

**Local tip:** Public park access only — no private banks.

**Nearby:** Combine with a short trail if fishing slows.

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## Rivers & creeks (public access only)

### 21. Scioto River — Griggs to downtown corridor

**Fish:** Smallmouth bass, channel catfish, freshwater drum, carp, sunfish; seasonal white bass / sauger-family fish depending on stretch.

**Bait:** Soft plastics & small crankbaits for smallmouth; cut bait / crawlers for cats; corn/dough where carp fishing is practiced.

**Web:** Corridor parks via [Columbus Recreation & Parks](#) · [Griggs](#)

**Local tip:** Pick one public park access — don't hop fences. Summer evenings can be excellent.

**Nearby:** Grandview / Franklinton / downtown food by exit point.

### 22. Scioto River — south of downtown (public parks)

**Fish:** Channel catfish, smallmouth, drum, carp, sunfish.

**Bait:** Cut bait and nightcrawlers for cats; plastics for bass; worms for panfish.

**Web:** [Columbus Recreation & Parks](#)

**Local tip:** Watch footing on riprap; tell someone your plan.

**Nearby:** South Side / German Village for a victory meal.

### 23. Olentangy River — Worthington / Clintonville

**Fish:** Smallmouth bass, sunfish, channel catfish, carp.

**Bait:** Light plastics & spinners for smallmouth; worms for sunfish; cut bait for cats.

**Web:** Trail/park context via [Columbus Recreation & Parks](#) · nearby [Highbanks Metro Park](#) (river corridor north)

**Local tip:** Bike-path traffic is high — cast with awareness.

**Nearby:** Clintonville coffee and High Street food.

### 24. Olentangy River — north toward Delaware County

**Fish:** Smallmouth, sunfish, catfish; clearer water pockets after stable weather.

**Bait:** Soft plastics, small crankbaits, worms, cut bait.

**Web:** Confirm each lot via [Delaware County / ODNR maps](#) before you go

**Local tip:** Mix of park and private land — public lots only.

**Nearby:** Powell / Delaware food on the drive.

### 25. Big Walnut Creek — east / southeast parks

**Fish:** Smallmouth / rock bass, sunfish, channel catfish.

**Bait:** Light plastics & spinners; worms; cut bait in deeper holes.

**Web:** Park pages vary by stretch — start with [Three Creeks](#) / city park listings

**Local tip:** After storms, wait for safer levels and clearer water.

**Nearby:** Gahanna / Reynoldsburg / Canal Winchester by stretch.

### 26. Alum Creek — below-dam / creek sections (public only)

**Fish:** Smallmouth, sunfish, catfish; dam areas can hold seasonal runners — follow special rules.

**Bait:** Soft plastics, small jigs, worms, cut bait.

**Web:** [Alum Creek State Park](#) · [Alum Creek Lake Fishing Area](#)

**Local tip:** Dam current is dangerous — read every sign.

**Nearby:** Westerville / Lewis Center for supplies.

### 27. Blacklick Creek — east-side park access

**Fish:** Sunfish, small bass, occasional catfish.

**Bait:** Ultra-light worms, tiny jigs, small spinners.

**Web:** Nearby park hubs: [Blacklick Woods](#) · [Three Creeks](#)

**Local tip:** Small water = light tackle and patience.

**Nearby:** East Columbus for bait/snacks.

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## Easy day-trip & “worth the drive” options

### 28. A.W. Marion State Park — Circleville area

**Fish:** Largemouth bass, bluegill, crappie, channel catfish.

**Bait:** Worms & small jigs; soft plastics for bass; cut bait for cats.

**Web:** [A.W. Marion State Park](#)

**Local tip:** Half-day outing; check park hours before you leave.

**Nearby:** Circleville for a simple meal on the way back.

### 29. Slate Run Metro Park

**Fish:** Pond panfish and bass **only where fishing is posted** (some park water is wildlife-only).

**Bait:** Worms, tiny jigs, soft plastics.

**Web:** [Slate Run](#)

**Local tip:** Confirm allowed ponds before you cast; trails make a fine backup plan.

**Nearby:** Southeast suburbs for gas and food.

### 30. Chestnut Ridge Metro Park

**Fish:** Panfish / bass where posted on park waters.

**Bait:** Worms, small jigs, soft plastics.

**Web:** [Chestnut Ridge](#)

**Local tip:** Combine with a short ridge walk so the day isn't only waiting on a bite.

**Nearby:** Southeast suburbs before you head north.

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## Half-day sampler menus

**NE Columbus:** Hoover → Sharon Woods → Westerville food

**NW metro:** Griggs or O'Shaughnessy → Dublin coffee

**East side:** Rocky Fork or Pickerington Ponds → Gahanna/Pickerington bite

**Teach-a-kid:** Homestead Park or Madison Lake → pack snacks → quit early

**Day-trip:** Deer Creek or Delaware Lake — leave early, home by dinner

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## Gear quick list

- ☐ License + ID
  - ☐ Rod/reel + spare line
  - ☐ Hooks, sinkers, bobbers, soft plastics, nightcrawlers (as allowed)
  - ☐ Pliers / clippers / net / measuring device
  - ☐ Cooler + ice (if keeping)
  - ☐ Headlamp for dawn/dusk
  - ☐ First-aid basics
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# Trip log

| Date | Spot # / name | Target fish | Bait used | Caught? | Notes |
|------|---------------|-------------|-----------|---------|-------|
|      |               |             |           |         |       |
|      |               |             |           |         |       |
|      |               |             |           |         |       |
|      |               |             |           |         |       |
|      |               |             |           |         |       |

Favorite of the 30: \_\_\_\_\_

Best bait day: \_\_\_\_\_

Next spot to try: \_\_\_\_\_

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